Draft - expert review pending

Note: This unit is complete and passes the platform's automated checks, but it is not reviewed yet. So, treat its sources and claims with care. You are encouraged to report errors and provide feedback.

Topic 6.1 - What a journal is for

A real classroom situation

A trainee teacher at a college in Hyderabad is told to submit a "reflective journal" at the end of her practicum. She hands in a notebook with an entry for every day of the eight weeks. Each entry reads like this:

> "Monday: Taught grade 7, chapter 4, section 2. Completed the exercise. Homework set. Tuesday: Taught grade 7, chapter 4, section 3. Pupils were noisy. Gave extra work. Wednesday: Test conducted."

The supervisor marks it as "poor - no reflection shown". The trainee is upset. "I wrote every day," she says. "What more did she want?"

A reflective journal is not these four things

A journal is not...	What it does	What a journal does instead
Diary	Records personal events and feelings without analysis	Analyses professional events for learning and improvement
Lesson plan	Sets out intentions before teaching what will happen	Reviews what happened after teaching and why it happened
Scheme of work	Maps curriculum content across a term or year	Explores individual teaching episodes in depth
Incident report	Records facts of a specific event for accountability	Interprets events for personal professional growth

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What the supervisor wanted was not more writing. It was a different *kind* of writing. The trainee had kept a diary. The supervisor wanted a journal. This topic explains the difference.

Explanation

A reflective journal is not a diary

A Reflective journal records teaching experiences *in order to learn from them*. A diary records events *in order to remember them*. The difference is the purpose, and the purpose determines everything else. A diary entry says what happened. A journal entry says what happened, why it mattered, and what the writer will do differently as a result.

The trainee's notebook was a diary. It answered the question "what did I do each day?" A reflective journal answers the question "what did I learn from what I did, and how will that change what I do next?" Both are useful records. But only one is a journal.

A reflective journal is not a lesson plan

A lesson plan prepares you for a lesson that has not happened yet. A journal reflects on a lesson that has already happened. The two are related - a good journal entry may change your next lesson plan

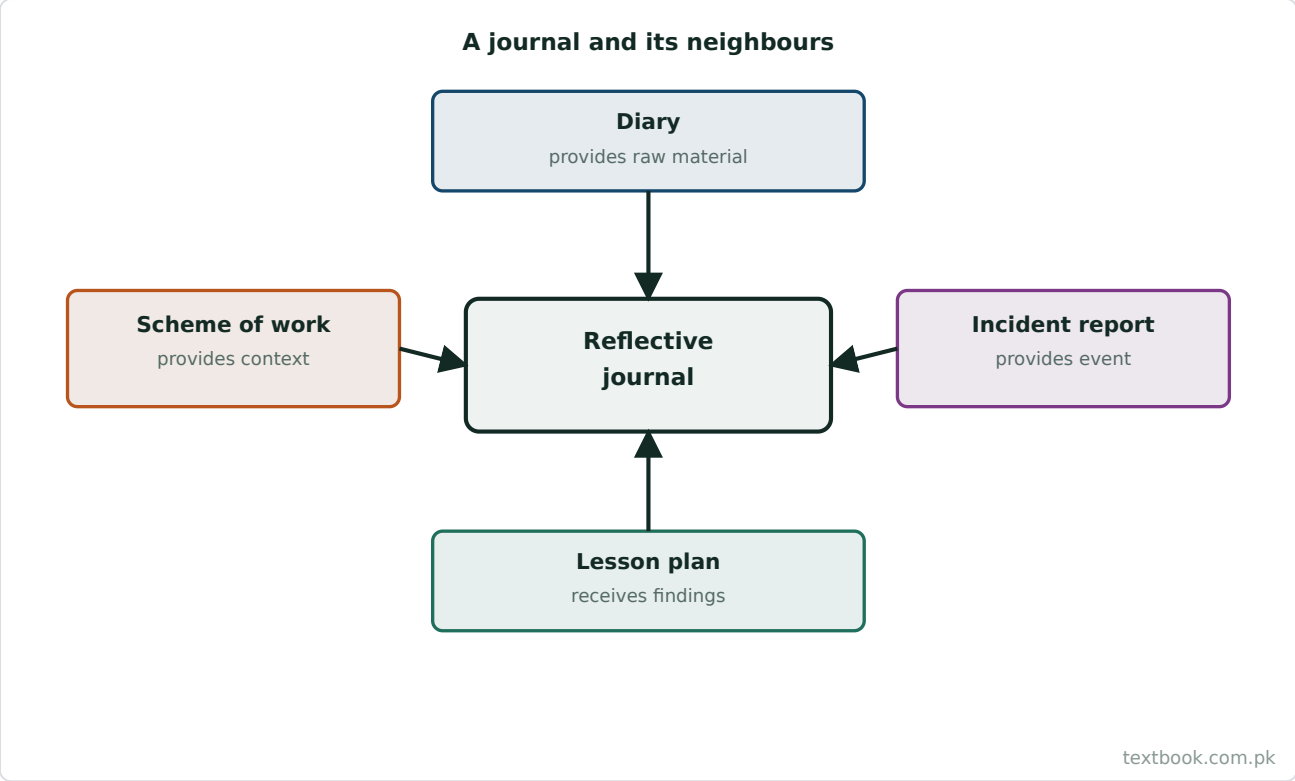
- but they are different documents with different timings and different purposes. A trainee who writes "tomorrow I will do X" in a journal is writing a lesson plan, not a reflection.

A reflective journal is not a scheme of work

A scheme of work maps coverage across a term: which chapters, in which order, by which week. A journal examines the *experience* of teaching those chapters. The scheme of work says "week 3, chapter 4". The journal says "chapter 4 did not go the way I expected, and here is why". The scheme of work is a map. The journal is an analysis of the journey.

A reflective journal is not an incident report

An incident report documents a specific event (an accident, a disciplinary issue, a complaint) for an official record. A journal examines incidents for the writer's own learning. An incident report is written for someone else (a head, a board). A journal is written primarily for the writer - though on this course, it is also read and marked by a supervisor, which is a complication Topic 6.2 addresses.



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What a journal actually does

Jasper (2003) describes three things a reflective journal does that no other document does:

1. **It makes thinking visible.** Writing forces you to be specific. A vague thought ("that lesson was bad") has to become a specific claim ("the pupils could not answer question 3 because I had not taught the prerequisite concept") in order to be written down. That specificity is itself a form of analysis.

2. **It creates a record that can be revisited.** A teacher who keeps a journal for a term can look back across weeks and see patterns they could not see day to day. "The same kind of question confuses them every time" is a finding that only exists across entries, not within one.

3. **It supports the reflective cycle.** A journal is the medium in which the cycle from Unit 5 runs. The description is written, the analysis is written, the decision is written, and the next entry's opening sentence

(the return arrow) is written. Without a journal, the cycle has no container.

Common misconception: "a journal is a diary." It is the most common confusion in assessed reflection files across Pakistani teacher education. Trainees write diaries because diaries feel natural and journals feel demanding. The mark scheme distinguishes them: a diary gets credit for regularity and coverage; a journal gets credit for analysis and learning. On this course, the assessed file is a journal, and a diary submitted as a journal is marked down for lacking reflection.

Activity: Journal or something else?

Work in pairs. About 20 minutes.

Each pair takes the five written extracts below. For each one, decide whether it is a **reflective journal entry** or something else (diary, lesson plan, scheme of work, incident report). Write one sentence naming the evidence.

1. "Week 5: chapter 4 (fractions), sections 1-3. Assessment: exercise 4.1."
2. "The group task took longer than planned. I think the instructions were unclear. Next time I will write them on the board before the groups start."
3. "Grade 8, period 3. Zainab and Sana argued during the lesson. Sent both to the head teacher."
4. "Monday: grade 7 period 2. Tuesday: grade 8 period 4. Wednesday: grade 7 period 1."
5. "I asked a question and nobody answered. I think I have been asking questions that only the top pupils can answer. I need to design questions at three difficulty levels."

Then swap with another pair. Where you disagree, say which of the three purposes of a journal (making thinking visible, creating a revisible record, supporting the cycle) is present or absent.

Check your understanding

1. **Remember** Name the four things a reflective journal is not.

2. **Understand** In two or three sentences, explain the difference between a diary and a reflective journal. Use a school example.

3. **Apply** A trainee writes, "Tomorrow I will teach chapter 5 using group work." Is this a journal entry? Justify in one sentence.

4. **Apply** A teacher writes, "The pupils failed the test. The test was hard." Which kind of document is this most likely to be, and what would make it a journal entry?

Summary

A reflective journal is not a diary (which records events), a lesson plan (which prepares for teaching), a scheme of work (which maps coverage), or an incident report (which documents an event). A journal examines teaching experience in order to learn from it: it makes thinking visible, creates a revisible record, and supports the reflective cycle. The trainee who confuses a diary with a journal is

> the most common failure in assessed reflection files. The difference is the presence of analysis, not the regularity of the writing.

Self-assessment checklist

Sign in to sync your ticks across devices.

- [ ] I can name four things a reflective journal is not and explain the difference in each case.
- [ ] I can take a written extract and classify it as a journal or something else, with evidence.
- [ ] I can explain the three purposes a journal serves.
- [ ] I can say why regularity alone does not make a diary a journal.

Try this at your practicum school

Find one piece of writing from your own practicum so far - a lesson plan, a diary, a note to yourself. Read it and ask: is this a journal? If not, what would I have to add to make it one? Write one sentence naming the missing element.

Summative task

Here is a page from a trainee's notebook:

> "Monday 6 March: Taught grade 7 English. Lesson: essay writing. Did the introduction together. Pupils wrote their own. Most introductions were copied from the example. I told them not to copy."

> "Tuesday 7 March: Taught grade 7 English. Lesson: essay writing, the body paragraph. Used the board. Pupils copied the structure. Better than Monday."

Write 150 to 200 words that (a) names what kind of document this is and gives two pieces of evidence, (b) says what a reflective journal entry on the same Monday lesson would include that this does not, and (c) rewrites the Monday entry as a reflective journal entry that reaches the analysis stage.

Mini-rubric

Criterion	Levels
Document classification	0-2: correctly identified as a diary with two pieces of evidence / identified with one piece / wrong.
What a journal would add	0-2: names analysis (why copying happened, what to try, how to know it worked) / a general addition / none.
Rewrite	0-3: a rewrite that reaches the analysis stage with a testable hypothesis (**Analyze*: the rewrite turns on the specific content of the Monday lesson) / a rewrite that stays descriptive / no real rewrite.
Clarity	0-1: within the word band / not.

Further reading

Jasper, M. (2003). *Beginning reflective practice*. Nelson Thornes. Chapter 2 sets out what a reflective journal is and what it is not.

Pendrey, A. (2022). *The little book of reflective practice*. Routledge. Chapter 1 distinguishes reflective writing from descriptive writing (scope-limited to method; early-years setting).

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Yes

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